

Title: Gamifying Growth through Seasonal Delight

Subtitle: Boosting core feature adoption and engagement through whimsical UX interventions

Summary: Throughout the year, a company managing over 1,500 employees across North America released seasonal themes to drive platform affinity. This project introduced a "ghost hunt" gamification layer to significantly increase the adoption of both new and legacy features within the mobile app.

- **Role:** Product designer and Lead illustrator
- **Timeline:** 2 months
- **Deliverables:** In-app "ghost hunt," omni-channel email campaign, and performance analytics reports
- **Key Metric:** 64% average email interaction rate; 164% average increase in feature adoption; Up to 550% boost in specific profile interactions.

Problem

After eighteen months in production, data showed that several key features on the platform remained underutilized. These touchpoints were critical for operational efficiency, and the product team aimed to increase adoption to improve the overall staff experience. However, internal business rules prohibited mandating usage (the "stick" approach), so we had to find an organic, incentive-based ("carrot") way to drive interactions.

Solution

With Halloween approaching, the design team proposed a seasonal campaign to guide users toward these features—including the upcoming "Dark Mode" release. We launched an omni-channel campaign consisting of a series of timed emails and five hidden "ghosts" placed strategically near high-value, low-usage components. Each ghost was introduced via email with a unique backstory, transforming a standard UI task into a narrative-driven "hunt."

Development and implementation

The Thematic Foundation

Throughout 2026 our platform had seasonal themes releases, and Halloween would be combined with Día de los Muertos, with the campaign expanding from October 20th to November 3rd. I finished illustrating all elements by mid-September and the placements were decided not long after that.

Ideation & Strategy

During a stakeholder meeting, a concern was raised regarding the underutilization of features like "Event Check-in" and "Task Management." Since adherence relied heavily on manager encouragement rather than system requirements, the design team suggested using the seasonal theme as an awareness vehicle. As the lead illustrator and designer for the ghosts, I was responsible for the visual identity of the campaign, while collaborating with the team to architect the campaign flow, define the UX copy for the ghost backstories, and create the technical documentation for precise asset placement. The team also pitched to stakeholders together, securing full creative autonomy for the campaign.

Scaling

Initially, we planned for a cross-platform campaign, since the theme would be launched for both app and desktop. However, after consulting with the engineering team, we opted to focus only on the mobile, given the strict two-week production window. This allowed us to maximize impact within a smaller, more controlled user pool while ensuring high-quality execution.

Implementation

By analyzing our product analytics, we identified four high-impact features with the lowest engagement:

- Check-in button: Real-time tracking of arrival at the events
- Profile photo button: Account personalization
- Tasks page: Core hub for assignment management
- Add photos button: Direct media uploads from the field

To maintain the "hunt" integrity, we established a specific feedback loop: when a user discovered a ghost, a modal appeared revealing its unique backstory. Once closed, the ghost would disappear, ensuring a one-time interaction that felt like a genuine "find." We also decided to leverage this high-traffic moment to launch Dark Mode. By coordinating with the mobile development team, we pulled the release forward, making the "Dark Mode Toggle" the final destination of the campaign.

Alongside the in-app experience, we developed scheduled emails and a "manager's one-pager" to ensure internal teams could support the staff during the live campaign.

Meet the ghosts

Each ghost had its own unique personality, that we matched to where they would be hiding. Their names are a spookification of drink-related words.

- Ghoulfashioned: An energetic ghost who floats between guests, ensuring their glass is always full.
- Piña Ghoulada: A friendly and whimsical ghost who oversees gift bags and takeaways, making sure every guest leaves with a little something special.
- Phantom Fizz: An elegant ghostly mixologist who leaves behind recipes for forgotten classic cocktails.
- Boourbon: A sweet-natured ghost who makes sure all the bottles are filled and neatly arranged before the party starts.
- Apparition Spiritz: A nurturing ghost who encourages the newest team members, leaving them encouraging little messages.

Metric tracking

Having tracked the app for six months prior, we had a robust baseline for user behavior. We used Pendo to track the new flows, and after the campaign was over, we presented a comprehensive performance report to the company's stockholders.

- **Adoption Spike:** All five targeted features saw increased engagement, with "Edit Profile" seeing a 550% boost.
- **Behavioral Attribution:** 66% of the initial Dark Mode adoption was directly attributed to users who engaged with the ghost hunt.

- **Email-to-App Conversion:** Data confirmed that ghosts with higher email open rates saw proportionally stronger component performance, validating our omni-channel strategy.

Conclusion:

I recognize that the meticulous care put into a product is not always visible to the end-user, who is there to do their job and get on with their lives. However, this didn't stop me from pouring my best into every seasonal theme. For the Halloween campaign, with our five friendly ghosts that I so enjoyed doing, the effort was even higher. While my mind was focused on meeting hard engagement KPIs, my goal was to provide a moment of genuine delight—turning a routine work tool into something that could make a user's day a little brighter.